

International Journal of Fashion Studies
Volume 12 Number 2

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Received 19 July 2024; Accepted 25 February 2025; Published Online October 2025

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‘Vivre l’époque’: A relational reading of mood, selfhood and feminist world-making in the work of Sonia Rykiel

ABSTRACT

This article aims to recontextualize the work of French fashion designer Sonia Rykiel from an affiliative point of view by disentangling the various relations caught up in the materialization of her designs. In her démode manifesto from 1977, Rykiel states that her design practice was a way of ‘translating the political mood of the day’, a statement against fashion’s time-based hierarchies of trends and diktats. Through a concentric, relational reading of these creations, informed by mood theory, as well as feminist notions related to the sociocultural milieu of Rykiel, such as Hélène Cixous’s notion of écriture féminine and Antoinette Fouque’s libido creandi, the article aims to draw out the importance of a relational perspective for fashion studies. By elucidating how a design poetic can express the changes in mood of a certain time, place and sociocultural milieu, we can understand how it can, in turn, affect this milieu and its mood.

KEYWORDS

fashion design
mood theory
démode
feminism
affiliative fashion
motherhood
écriture féminine
Hélène Cixous

1 INTRODUCTION: MOODS, LA MODE AND A MODE DE VIE

‘Je cherchais un style de vie, non plus lié à l’image mais à la politique du moment, une manière de bouger plus androgyne, plus moderne, une

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1. 'What I did was to create a way of living, no longer attached to an image but to the politics of the day'.

sensualité du quotidien qui convenait plus à la vie que les femmes menaient' (Sonia Rykiel in Fouque 2008).¹

Sonia Rykiel's statement that her fashion creations were tied to a way of living and to the politics of her day is a starting point for this relational reading of her creations through the lens of contemporary theories of mood and affect in fashion studies. This article builds on my previous analysis of Rykiel's work and the *démode* through the idea of physical as well as social movement (Van Godtsenhoven 2024).

In trying to disentangle the various relations at work in her creations, this investigation aims to follow a concentric structure, going from Rykiel's close relations (with herself, her daughter and the wearers of her garments) to her wider cultural, social and political environment (collaborators, authors and feminist thinkers). However, it must be noted that these relations are deeply entangled and cannot be separated neatly, since Rykiel's life illustrates the second-wave feminist concept that the 'personal is political' and that her private life, her creative life and her political life were greatly enmeshed ('la mode, la robe et le monde' in her show notes for *Spring/Summer 2005*).

By engaging with critical concepts pertaining to mood theory as a strand of affect theory, this article aims to draw out the importance of fashion and dress as relational objects that bind together people, ideas, affects and cultural or social moods (Filippello and Parkins 2023: 14). Mood can here be understood as an attunement to the world, with Martin Heidegger's definition as 'an overall orientation to the world which brings it into view a certain way' (quoted in Felski and Fraiman 2012: vi). Fashion designers, as creators of material goods, are both affected by moods and create (new) moods; think of how most fashion collections today start from a mood board. There is a co-constitutive, circulatory principle between fashion design and mood, with both responding to each other: 'Far from merely reflecting the moods of place and time, fashion contributes to the production of cultural structures of feeling' (2023: 263) writes Harriette Richards.

This central notion of 'structures of feeling' as posited by Raymond Williams in 1977 is taken up by contemporary mood thinkers from sociology, cultural studies and literary studies (Highmore 2016, 2017; Flatley 2008; Sheehan 2018; Filippello and Parkins 2023) to affiliate something as elusive as mood with the more mundane, material world of fashion creation. In their introduction to *Fashion and Feeling: The Affective Politics of Dress*, Filippello and Parkins describe the importance of structures of feeling to shifts in fashion:

how a set of social changes in a precise historical situation can manifest itself in the attitudes of a given group of people, formally registering as (shifts in) manners, language, dress, or style – and finally, how we might come to feel a sense of belonging based on our sharedness in the sensitivity expressed in the clothes (or their representations).

(2023: 2)

These notions of belonging and a shared sensitivity can help us to critically look at the shifts taking place in sociocultural moods and in fashions at a specific moment and place in time, such as Rykiel's *démode*. Structures of feeling help us to understand the role of mood and shifting tastes in the world-making practices of fashion.

Aside from the concept of structures of feeling, recent developments in mood theory serve to think through fashion creation as world-making. Rita

Felski and Susan Fraiman describe mood as something more durational than affect: ‘Moods are usually described as ambient, vague, diffuse, hazy, and intangible, rather than intense, and they are often contrasted to emotions in having a longer duration [...]. Mood is like the weather’ (2012: v). In her influential work ‘Cruel optimism’, Lauren Berlant characterizes the contemporary political mood by ‘the energy of feeling relational, general, reciprocal’ (2010: 43).

With regard to this reciprocation, Jonathan Flatley reasons that ‘we find ourselves in moods that have already been inhabited by others, that have already been shaped or put into circulation, and that are already there around us’ (2008: 5). Even though moods are ephemeral, they act as connectors ‘between ostensibly separate entities: self and other, films and viewers, thought and feeling, scholarship and daily life’ (Felski and Fraiman 2012: xii). Moods can lubricate the difference between personal feelings, inherited mood-worlds, political moods and material creations. As in the French expression *l’air du temps*, fashion is present both in the psychic mood that envelops us as well as in the garments that envelop our bodies. Rosie Findlay writes that ‘fashion draws mood to the surface where it can be seen, transforming something immaterial and perceived into something that can be worn, felt in a different way and, crucially, observed’ (2022: 146). Etymologically, fashion is affiliated with mood: Elizabeth Sheehan remarks that

In French, *mode* means mood and fashion, and it links both to the sense of the ‘just now’ (*modo*) at the heart of modernity and modernism. Accordingly, fashion (understood as a prevailing style of dress) is often said to reflect, express, or capture the characteristic feeling or ‘spirit’ of a given time and place.

(2018: 28)

Similarly, Rykiel stated in press interviews that she is not making *mode* (‘fashion’) but a *mode de vie* (‘way of living’).² The personal and the cultural are hence interwoven in fashion moods: ‘Seen this way, fashion and feeling interfold in gauging the “mood”, or “weather”, of our time [...]. Mood can be characterized as a mutual becoming, then, enabled by the material properties of dress’ (Filippello and Parkins 2023: 16). Drawing on these concepts and these thinkers, the following aims to demonstrate how fashion can be seen as a relational process which affiliates the designer, the wearer, the mood of the era, people and ideas into an object. With Williams, we can learn how to understand ‘the specific relationships through which works are made and move’ (1986: 28).

2 RYKIEL’S DÉMODE

‘Le tricot, c’est une façon de vivre l’époque’ (Rykiel 1979: 40).³

Sonia Rykiel, the eldest of five sisters, was born in Paris in a Russo-Roumanian émigré Jewish family in 1930 (Figure 1). As an unruly child from an intellectual, bourgeois family, Rykiel dreamed of becoming an actress and writing. Her contradictory public statements throughout her life add to the unreliability of her character, as in a novel: ‘Je vis dans l’équivoque, le miraculeux’ (Rykiel 1979: 11).⁴

Married at a young age to boutique owner Sam Rykiel, she started to have some dresses altered when pregnant with her daughter Nathalie in 1955 because the available maternity fashions were not to her liking, and

2. ‘J’ai créé un mode de vie plus qu’une mode’. Written interview responses in Sonia Rykiel brand archives, 2009.
3. ‘Knitwear is a way of living your era’.
4. ‘I live in ambiguity, in the miraculous’.

5. The word 'matrescence' was first quoted by anthropologist Dana Raphael, describing the changing identity and physical and psychic process of becoming a mother. It has recently been taken up by a new generation of writers such as Lucy Jones, whose book *Matrescence* was published in 2023.
6. 'At first, I destroyed, I undid what I was doing. I did not feel accounted for. It was not me, it did not correspond with who I was. It was fashion, but it was not mine'.



Figure 1: Dominique Issermann, *Portrait of Sonia Rykiel*, 1980 © Dominique Issermann.

her gamine body type was different from the fashionable hourglass ideal. She wanted fashionable and comfortable dresses, and it was these *robes pour futures mamans* that were some of her first creations for the Laura boutique owned by Sam. Rykiel's pregnancy and process of becoming a mother or 'matrescence', was an important creative catalyst.⁵ After her son Jean-Philippe was born in 1961, she was designing dresses under her own name for the Laura boutique from 1963 to 1968. In 1965, she started her own brand: 'J'ai d'abord détruit, défilé ce que je faisais. Je n'y trouvais pas mon compte. Ça n'était pas moi, ça ne me correspondait pas. C'était la mode, mais ça n'était pas la mienne' (Rykiel 1979: 19).⁶

When Sonia divorced Sam in 1968 and opened her own Sonia Rykiel boutique at 6, Rue de Grenelle, this act of personal and professional liberation happened in the context of the larger May 1968 student uprisings in the background, particularly in the area of Saint-Germain-des-Prés. In the same area, Antoinette Fouque, founder of the group Psychoanalyse et Politique (Psych et Po) and co-founder of the Mouvement de la Libération des Femmes (MLF), was organizing feminist debates and marches and, in 1973, established the feminist publishing house Éditions des femmes. As a single-sex feminist movement, the MLF was focused on reproductive justice, equal rights and challenging patriarchal societal structures, resembling the actions of the

Women’s Liberation Movement in the United States, yet with very different theoretical underpinnings. The MLF was founded at the occupied Sorbonne in Paris in May 1968 in the wake of but also as a reaction against the masculinist student revolt. The founders, including Fouque, Josiane Chanel and Monique Wittig, were mainly academics and intellectuals, using Marxist, ecofeminist and psychoanalytic theory for thinking through feminist issues, establishing a discourse that is now still loosely known as French feminism, an umbrella term for a school of thought mainly focused on the difference between psychosexual subjectivities. Both the French feminists and the American Women’s Liberation Movement have been criticized from an intersectional point of view with regard to the class, sexual and racial privilege of these mostly white, heterosexual and middle-class women as well as their exclusion of queer/lesbian and trans voices (Crenshaw 1989).

It was in this social milieu of feminist, intellectual and political thinkers where, in 1976, Rykiel officially read her *démode* manifesto during the *Spring–Summer 1977 défilé*, bundling her design principles into her philosophy of the *démode* (‘de-fashion’), an aesthetic based on undone qualities in clothing and disobeying the time-based rhythms of seasons and trends. Her goal was to ‘destroy the laws, the diktats. I wanted to duplicate, overflow, unmeasure fashion. I wanted to unfold it, unroll it’ (Rykiel 1979: 19). Her rejection of the principles and hierarchies of fashion history demonstrates that ‘feelings are historical agents articulat[ing] modes of identity and forms of dis-identification’ (Highmore 2016: 145–46). Even though she had been, since 1973, the vice president of the *Chambre Syndicale de la Fédération française de la couture, du prêt-à-porter des couturiers et des créateurs de mode*, Rykiel was unwilling to follow the rules of the fashion industry; she would rather ‘faire la mode par rapport à son corps, à soi, et non pas à celui des couturiers’ (Rykiel 2011: 39).⁷

The *démode*, whilst not entirely an anti-fashion statement, was a manifesto of liberation from the rules of fashion history and the industry, an attempt to free the wearer from trends and time-based fashions (‘pas d’horaires pas de calculs’ [Rykiel 1979: 19]). Rykiel’s autodidactic approach gave her a sense of freedom from the rules of couture: she created garments with undone or zig-zagged hems, reversible garments with outward seams, layers on top of layers of knitwear (superposition) and added pockets everywhere; jersey dresses were to be worn over bare skin (without bras, epaulettes or linings), and she added words (e.g. ‘sensuous’) into the jersey. Jersey was her preferred material because it was elastic, sensual and clung to the body, following the lines of the body rather than shaping them: the first relationship, between body and garment, was for her one of harmony and intimate proximity. At the same time, knitwear was also a response to the broader cultural mood, a material expression and a way of ‘vivre l’époque’ (living one’s era), in Rykiel’s own words.

With Sara Ahmed, who writes that there is a reciprocal relationship between ourselves and our moods, we can see Rykiel’s jersey as a companion which we carry and which carries us, like a mood (2014: 15). Jersey translated the liberationist mood of a certain demographic of women into fashion, which was largely white, young, heterosexual and bourgeois.

A similar phenomenon took place in Italy, where in the 1970s a new generation of young *stilisti* started to use knitwear as a democratic and casual material, according to Maria Luisa Frisa and Danese: ‘knitwear has radically changed the way modern dressing is understood, by expressing and following shifts in social and cultural behaviors’ (2011: 47). A humble, organic and living

7. ‘to create fashion with regards to your own body, your self, and not that of the couturiers’.

material, jersey was democratic and adaptable, and did not have to be ironed or dry-cleaned like silk and satin. Jane Cattani, who was a public relations (PR) agent for Rykiel from 1984 to 1987, wore Rykiel in the 1970s in Geneva as a way of resisting her traditional environment:

To wear easy linen or jersey dresses by Rykiel in Geneva was an act of resistance against bourgeois dress codes with heavy fabrics. It was liberating. Also later, when we were doing showrooms, the jersey on the hanger was easy to handle, we could just take it out of the suitcase and it was ready to go, whereas colleagues from more conservative brands had to spend hours steaming silk dresses.

(2024: n.pag.)

It is clear that, even though Rykiel's garments rejected materials, shapes and functions perceived as bourgeois, wearing Rykiel was a way of rejecting bourgeois codes from within the milieu, showing how fashion can be both an expression of hegemonic structures and counter-hegemonic ideas.



Figure 2: Didier Destal, Sonia Rykiel, Spring–Summer 1976. © Maison Rykiel.

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In her 1979 memoir *Et je la voudrais nue*, Rykiel described the *démodé* as a way of creating fashion ‘with your mind for your body’, based on the entangled, privileged and pleasurable relationship between the body and the garment: ‘Plus grand, plus vaste, plus large, plus fort mais surtout à côté, du côté du corps, du côté du plaisir, du côté de l’envie. De son corps à soi, de son plaisir à soi, de son envie à soi’ (Rykiel 1979: 16).⁸ She also pointed out her own ambivalence about positing a philosophy that rejects the hierarchies of fashion and champions individualism, whilst at the same time becoming a new sort of dictator herself (Rykiel 1979: 20).⁹

8. ‘Much larger, much wider, much stronger but especially close to the body, closer to the side of pleasure, the side of desire. Of your own body, your own pleasure, your own desire’.
9. The *démodé*, is making fashion with your mind for your body, it’s taking some distance between your body and the forms invented by the ‘inventors of molds’, those ‘architects of style’ (which I am a part of). It’s to self-determine with regards to the folly, to the force, the knowledge of these ‘builders’ (which I am a part of). It’s playing, deviating, moving and smashing the image which they inscribe in letters of fire every six months[...]. The *démodé*, it’s individualism. The *démodé*, it’s the knowledge of the rapport between garment and body, the study of proportions body-garment, the alchemy of color-skin, the coherence between this reasonable knowledge and the delirium.

(Rykiel 1979: 20)



Figure 3: Didier Destal, Sonia Rykiel, Autumn–Winter 1976. © Maison Rykiel.

10. Mes enfants sont les branches de l'arbre. Ils sont si nécessaires. Pas que ça me suffit. Mais ils sont aussi mes nourritures. Le noyau. Je ne serai pas là sans l'amour d'un homme et des enfants, et sans en tirer une force que je retraduis autrement, et que ça devient, inoubliable.
(Fouque 2008)

The *démode* manifesto exemplifies how a changing cultural mood translates into 'temporal, spatial, and conceptual shifts' (Sheehan 2018: 27) in daily life, such as fashion changes, and how they can take unexpected forms. In the case of the *démode*, it was a language of forms tuned into the revolutionary societal changes and shifting feminist moods post-1968, a way of defining and living the era as a woman, and a way of dealing with its disarray and its difficulties with a silhouette that seems to be coming undone (Figure 2).

The *démode* was also Rykiel's way of positioning herself as a designer and wearer of her garments in relation to the world and the mood at work in the times she lived in and 'the mood-worlds she inherited' (Highmore 2017: 13). In what follows, I will try to disentangle the various relationships at play in the *démode* garments, concentrically from the intimate connection between body and garment to the relation between the garment and the social mood and politics of the day (Figure 3).

3 RELATION TO THE SELF: LE CORPS PROFOND, SONIA RYKIEL AND ÉCRITURE FÉMININE

In disentangling the relation between Rykiel as a designer and herself as a dressed subject, as well as her relationship to other women (the wearers), it becomes clear that a certain narcissistic impulse was at the basis of her creative drive: the first relation is that of the designer to her own body, her own desire and her own flesh, 'au plus profond du corps' (Rykiel 1979: 60), and it is that relation which she transposes to other women. Rykiel wrote about the process of becoming a designer as a reverse evolution from designing for 'others' (for the Laura boutique customer) to designing only for herself:

Real direction occurred only later when I began making clothes for me – Sonia Rykiel – and not for other women. I wanted to be the only woman in the world to be dressed entirely in my own way. What this selfish idea did was to give my clothes a unique signature. My customers began to dress the way I wanted to dress and therefore I made them unique in my own image.

(Actis-Grande 1985: n.pag.)

From this statement, we gather that the design process, even if focused on the designer's embodied sense of self, is also relational from the beginning: it happens between the designer's sense of self, her own body, other women and their bodies, and even her children.¹⁰ There is a mirroring, reflection, affiliation and multiplication happening between the designer's body and the bodies of other women, which act as the doubles of the designer.

Rykiel's concept of a unique signature, an *écriture*, closely tied to her own embodied experience echoes Hélène Cixous, who, in 'The Laugh of the Medusa', proposed the idea of an *écriture féminine*:

Woman must write her self: must write about women and bring women to writing, from which they have been driven away as violently as from their bodies – for the same reasons, by the same law, with the same fatal goal. Woman must put herself into the text – as into the world and into history – by her own movement[...]. I wished that that woman would write and proclaim this unique empire so that other women, other

unacknowledged sovereigns, might exclaim: I, too, overflow; my desires have invented new desires, my body knows unheard-of songs.
(Cixous et al. 1976: 1)

Cixous was the first of several French feminist literary authors who discussed the concept of *écriture féminine*, including Julia Kristeva (1984), Luce Irigaray (1985) and Monique Wittig (1980), as a way of writing to overcome imposed phallogocentric structures and hierarchies, which was closely tied to the female body and to desire.¹¹ Each of these authors shared a view that women were suppressed by patriarchal sociosexual structures but proposed different ways of dealing with these, from accentuating to eradicating psychosexual difference.

In Cixous’s essay ‘Sonia Rykiel en Traduction’, she implicitly made the case for interpreting Rykiel’s *démode* garments as an act of *écriture féminine*:

Le vêtement est originaire; son modèle, la sensation que le corps a de lui-même intérieurement; le secret du corps. [...] Je vais chez Rykiel comme chez une femme, comme ‘chez-moi’. Comme dans mon amie armoire, c’est-à-dire, je vais à l’intérieur, les yeux fermés. [...]

Que les coutures restent apparentes, c’est la non-pudeur propre à l’écriture. [...]

Cette robe c’est un rêve de corps, le rêve du voyage du corps dans le corps, de l’enfant dans la mère, de la femme dans la femme. [...]

La robe ne sépare pas le dedans du dehors, elle traduit en abritant. [...]

Sonia Rykiel fabrique le rêve du corps: faire librement corps avec les jambes, avec le ventre, avec les hanches, avec le bras, avec l’air, avec la mer, avec l’espace.

(1985: 7–11)¹²

Cixous read Rykiel’s work as relating to the private *jouissance* of the female body whereby a dress is a bonding mechanism between the body’s inside and the outside, and she also used the word *écriture* to designate the act of fashion creation. There is an entanglement between dress, body and self: ‘Tout continue. Les bords sont débordés; le vêtement ne s’arrête pas net, ne déclare pas ses lisières, ne ramasse pas ses frontières’ (Cixous 1985: 8).¹³ There was both an internal and an external *jouissance* in the act of wearing a Rykiel sweater; the inside-out seam is a sign of sexual and haptic pleasure, compared to the clitoris, activated by touch:

Couture, couture à l’envers [...] Je vous ai mises par-dessus parce que vous êtes si belles que je ne supportais pas de ne pas vous voir vraiment. Vous êtes la liberté, le bourrelet qu’on touche doucement puis plus vite pour jouir.

(Rykiel 1979: 55)¹⁴

Sexuality is bound up with others through the dress and its inside-out seams:

Les coutures, elles ont vu la pression du vécu. Elles sont dessus. [...] Alors si on les met par-dessus, elles peuvent dire, s’expliquer, parler de la beauté du contact-peau, de l’odeur-chair, du dévêtu, de la main qu’elles ont vue pénétrer sous le pull, la main de l’autre, celle qui n’est pas celle du mari mais du mari de l’autre.

(Rykiel 1979: 54)¹⁵

11. For a discussion about these writers’ contributions, differences and the issues surrounding essentialism, see Jones (1981).
12. The garment is at the origin: its model, the sensation which the body has of itself; the secret of the body [...] I go to Rykiel as one goes to woman, like going home. Like I go to my friend the closet, meaning, I go inward, eyes closed. [...] That the seams should remain apparent is in the immodesty of writing. [...] This dress is a dream of the body, the dream of the journey of the body in the body, of the child in the mother, of the woman in the woman. [...] The dress does not separate the inside from the outside, she translates and shelters. [...] Sonia Rykiel creates the dream of the body: to freely ‘make’ the body with the legs, the belly, the hips, the arms, with the air, the sea, with space.
13. ‘I see-touch the body hidden in the body. [...] there is continuity, everything is continuous. It brims over the edges, the garment does not stop short, doesn’t declare its boundaries, does not gather in its frontier’.
14. Seams, seams, inside-out seams, [...] I have placed you on the exterior because you are so beautiful and I couldn’t stand to not really see you. You are the freedom, the bead which we softly touch, faster and faster for enjoyment.

15. The seams, they have seen the pressure of the lived (experience). They are on the inside [...]. So, if we place them outside, they can talk, explain, speak of the beauty of the touch with the skin, of the scent of the flesh, of the undressed, of the hand which they saw penetrate under the sweater, the hand of the other, the hand which is not of the husband but of the other's husband.
16. 'But I came out as a woman in the world of women, surrounded by all of those who are not me but who are the same'.

With Elizabeth Ordoñez, we read how *écriture féminine* ties together the libidinal economies of the female body with the larger historical mood:

If woman learns to write herself through the unleashing of her boundless libidinal economy, she will find herself 'at the beginning of a new history', part of a process in which her personal history will intersect and blend with that of all women as well as with national and world history.

(1987: 47)

Furthermore, in Ann Rosalind Jones's words, 'to the extent that the female body is seen as a direct source of female writing, a powerful alternative discourse seems possible: to write from the body is to recreate the world' (1981: 252). Rykiel's design *écriture*, though self-centred, is reflective of a wider mood and circulating feminist ideas and is shaping these in turn. She incorporated an affective atmosphere and social mood to mediate her relation to herself.

4 DOUBLING, MIRRORING, OTHERING THE SELF

'Mais je suis sortie femme dans le monde des femmes, entouré de toutes celles qui sont pas moi mais qui sont les mêmes' (Rykiel 1979: 87).¹⁶

There is both a unification as well as a doubling or mirroring of personas happening in the way Rykiel is both the designer and wearer of the *démode* garments. Such a doubling or mirroring appears in the way she saw her models as doubles of herself and chose models with the same height as her, sending them onto the catwalk in pairs, trios or quadruples, almost as a band of sisters, modelled after her own image (and her 'tribe' of sisters). One has to consider here that the ideal body type was mostly young and able-bodied women with a *garçonne* physique like Rykiel's own, even if the *démode* garments were able to fit various forms.

Jane Cattani, Rykiel's PR and press liaison from 1984 to 1987, says there was a very familial atmosphere between the staff, the models and Rykiel, and that the designer used her and other women from the boutique (shop assistants) as 'at hand' models, fitting pullovers and needling them whilst they were working on their desks. This familiarity and blurring of professional roles were part of the working atmosphere: 'We were all very seduced by her. She was very independent and very feminine, she was a role model for all of us' (Cattani 2024: n.pag.). With regards to Rykiel being a role model and being mirrored by others, some highly visible intellectual and bohemian women of the Left Bank (including actress Anouk Aimée) were considered her troupe of followers; several dressed like her and, according to Cattani, would even dye their hair red. Rykiel's brand was very popular in the United States and Japan, because she herself was the epitome of la 'Parisienne', representing an aspirational stereotype of French elegance, insouciance and social privilege: 'Everyone modeled themselves after her' (2024: n.pag.), says Cattani. Hence, the 'Rykiel woman' or ideal customer was Rykiel herself; she was an automuse who dressed the wearers all in her own image. It is important to note that, given the Rykiel brand's upmarket pricing tier, her international customer base would have mostly belonged to the same higher middle-class milieus as herself and enjoyed similar privileges. In 1977, Rykiel designed models for the mail order catalogue *Les 3 Suisses*, reaching new audiences across Europe and

shocking some of her wealthy clients, who would no longer be the only ones wearing the label.

From an early age, Rykiel writes, she was aware of feeling double or of being an actor in a play: 'Je vivais double' (1979: 75). This 'doubleness' adds another level of relationality within the relation to the self, echoing Irigaray and Jones that '[s]he is indefinitely other in herself, that is undoubtedly the reason she is called temperamental, incomprehensible, perturbed, capricious' (Jones 1981: 250).

When pregnant with her daughter Nathalie, Rykiel felt ecstatic, untouchable, majestic and 'double enfin' (1979: 67). It was her pregnancy that set in motion her urge to create (Figure 4). In this respect, the *démode* can be seen

SONIA RYKIEL



Figure 4: Sonia Rykiel, Drawing for a maternity dress, 1969. © Maison Rykiel.

17. 'Indefinite dresses, which extend my double body, my double life, which mark my belly and show my curves'.
18. I wanted a lifestyle which was appropriate to the woman I was. This woman with children, this woman with men, this woman-at-home, this woman who lunches, dines, goes to the theater, this music-sound-lights-folly-desire-woman [...]. I wanted a plane mode, a travel mode, a luggage mode. I saw myself as a woman in departure mode surrounded by bags and children. Over the shoulder bags, backpacks, cross-body bags, children on each hand.
19. The word individual stems from the Latin *in-divisare*, un-dividable.
20. 'Each woman carries within her the entire form of all the others, each dress carries within her the entire form of all the others'.
21. 'I give birth to a collection with the same pains, the same fears, the same fascinations as I give birth to a child. The collection, I carry her within myself'.
22. 'the *libido creandi* of women (*creare* in Latin means both to create and to procreate) which I have called libido since long, refuses the binary division and connects procreation and creation to the maternal language'.

as a way of dressing which does not overcome this doubleness, but as a way of expressing it: the elasticity of the garments, and the way they allow for the body to stretch, swell and contain more than one body: 'Robes indéfinies, prolongeant mon double corps, ma double vie, marquant mon ventre et montrant mes formes' (Rykiel 1979: 43).¹⁷

By incorporating these maternal elements as part of the *démode* ready-to-wear collection, Rykiel unified concepts of maternity and daily wear: her *démode* designs swaddled the body in an envelope of soft, sensual and stretchy jersey material, accompanying the wearer in different phases of her life as well as at different times of the day. Her mood and her fashions were peripatetic, bohemian and relational to the other people in her life:

Je voulais un mode de vie approprié à cette femme que j'étais. Cette femme à enfants, cette femme à hommes, cette femme-maison, cette femme à déjeuners, dîners, théâtre, cette femme-musique-son-lumière-folie-désir. [...] Je voulais une mode-avion, une mode-voyage, une mode-bagage. Je me voyais en femme 'départ' entourée de sacs et d'enfants. Les sacs sur l'épaule, sur le dos, en travers du corps, les enfants au bout des bras.

(Rykiel 1979: 19)¹⁸

In the context of work on the maternal body and psyche by Iris Marion Young and Julia Kristeva, we can read Rykiel's pregnant embodiment as a form of autoeroticism. In the feeling of the body expanding, of being the source of the life-giving process, 'the pregnant woman recollects a primordial sexual continuity with the maternal body which Kristeva calls "jouissance"' (Hirsch 1981: 210). Young argues that the pregnant subject is 'decentered, split' between past and future, and that the transcendence of the subject/object distinction undermines the Cartesian principle of the unified individual (1984: 46).¹⁹ Because the pregnant body is in flux, the boundaries between I and not-I, between self and other, between creator and participant are blurred; Rykiel responded to that feeling with her dresses. This maternal, 'pregnant state of being' is how Rykiel described her creative process with regard to creating collections: 'Chaque femme porte en elle la forme entière de toutes les autres, chaque robe porte en elle la forme entière des autres' (Rykiel 1988: 16).²⁰ She also compared creating a collection and its concomitant anxieties and pain to the process of birthing a child: 'J'accouche d'une collection avec les mêmes douleurs, les mêmes peurs, les mêmes fascinations que l'enfantement. La collection, je la porte en moi' (Rykiel 1979: 24).²¹

This pregnant state of being and drive to create is what Fouque called the 'libido creandi' or *libido2*, uniting the acts of creation, procreation and liberation by women.

Applied to Rykiel, an affiliative fashion between creator/mother and child/garment emerges.²² Rather than an *écriture féminine*, Fouque advocated for an *écriture utérine*, tied to the uterus as a source of life, based on principles of orality, (pro)creation and the *libido creandi*:

Une écriture qui ferait retour au moment de la gestation pour sortir de l'écriture matricide et aller vers le *matriciel*; une écriture qui n'écraserait pas l'oralité, qui ne la soumettrait ni ne s'y soumettrait, mais qui

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partagerait, qui ouvrirait à la *géné(t)alité* de la langue. [...] Une écriture articulée à une *libido creandi* qui signifie autant création génésique (procréer) que création artistique (créer). Une création par l’écriture qui soit articulée à la chair, à la pensée génésique. Et une maison pour les femmes, habitantes du monde. Il s’agit de publier en tenant compte du temps de la fécondité et de la gestation.

(2007: 24)²³

This idea of a matrixial *écriture* both incorporates intellectual ideas and moods circulating post-1968, such as the post-structural, psychoanalytical and deconstructivist writings by Roland Barthes, Jacques Derrida, Michel Foucault, Gilles Deleuze, Jacques Lacan et al., but is also a reaction against these thinkers, who did not (often) include a feminist perspective. As ‘habitantes du monde’, women co-created the outside world: ‘La création dérive de la procréation: elle est la traduction, dans tous les champs de l’activité humaine, du même désir de faire œuvre, donner de l’énergie au monde, s’affirmer, laisser une trace visible et utile à ceux qui viendront’ (Fouque 2013: n.pag.).²⁴

5 RELATION TO THE OUTSIDE WORLD: ‘LA POLITIQUE DU MOMENT’

‘Accusée, levez-vous. Vous êtes la première robe que j’ai inventée, “La Divine”. Comment avez-vous aidé ce mouvement naissant (le MLF)?’ (Rykiel 2008: 38).

‘Je cherchais un style de vie non plus lié à l’image mais à la politique du moment, une manière de bouger plus androgyne, plus moderne, une sensualité du quotidien qui convenait plus à la vie que les femmes menaient’ (Rykiel 2008: 38).²⁵

In this prose by Rykiel, the imaginary ‘Divine’ red dress, which she described as the first dress she created, the primal scream as it were, is asked about her position and connection to the nascent MLF movement in the 1960s (the MLF was founded in 1968): ‘Je sais que tout a commencé avec le mouvement hippie. Prise de position du terrain-espace’ (Rykiel 1979: 176).²⁶ As a relational object, the dress responded that she wanted to create a way of being ‘tied to the politics of the day, a way of moving in a more modern, androgynous and sensual way, tied to women’s daily lives’ (Rykiel 2008: 38). Here, Rykiel knitted together notions of the external (politics of the day) and the internal (movement of the body) into one garment. The dress has agency and is not worn as a shield against the outside world but rather as a way of fusing with it:

il n’est pas un masque, il est le lien, la représentation exacte de ce que j’aime porter, de ce que je veux voir porter, de cet uniforme qui n’est pas uniformité mais forme unique. Il a la forme de la rue que j’habite, de l’avion que je prends, du train qui m’emporte, du chaud que je poursuis, du froid que je ne supporte pas, de la nourriture qui m’enchant, du lit, de mes enfants, de l’amour. Il vit à ma vie. Il dépend de la guerre, de la grève, des massacres. Il s’infiltr, se coule dans mes idées. Il explose quand j’éclate et se calme quand je m’endors.

(Rykiel 1979: 27)²⁷

The garment is conjoined to the body, as well as reflective and co-constitutive of the wider sociocultural mood and circulating feminist ideas. In the dress, the self and not-self are wrought together; it is a site where public moods are

23. A way of writing which would return to the moment of gestation, for exiting the matrixial literature and going towards the matrixial; a way of writing which would not erase orality, which wouldn’t suppress and wouldn’t be oppressed, but which would share, which would be open to the geni(t)ality of language[...]. A way of writing expressed by a *libido creandi* which signifies both reproductive creation (procreation) as well as artistic creation (creation). An act of creation by writing which is expressed in relation to the flesh, and to the reproductive thought. And a house for women, inhabitants of the world. It’s about publishing whilst taking into account the time of fertility and of gestation.

24. Creation is based on procreation: it is the translation, in all the fields of human activity, of the same desire to make work, of giving energy to the world, to affirm oneself and leave a visible and useful trace to those who will come later.

25. ‘Will the defendant please rise. You are the first dress I have invented, “The Divine”. How did you help this nascent movement (the MLF)?’ ‘I was looking for a way of living, no longer attached to an image but to the politics of the day, a way of moving more androgynously, more modern, a quotidian sensuality which corresponded to the life women were living’.

26. 'I know that everything started with the hippie movement. Taking up position of the ground-space'.
27. the garment is not a mask, it is a bond, the exact representation of what I want to wear, of what I would like to see being worn, of this uniform which is not uniformity but unique form. It has the shape of the street I inhabit, the plane I take, the train which carries me, of the heat I pursue, of the cold I cannot stand, of the food which enchants me, of the bed, the children, love. It lives on my

'experienced through the body' (Gorton 2007: 334). In typical second-wave fashion, the dress imbricates the personal with the political. As Carlson and Stewart point out, '[a]ttention to mood opens up the everyday stuff of which lives are made in the midst of world-historical events' (Carlson and Stewart cited in Parkins 2020: 6). Instead of merely reflecting a place and time, fashion engages with the mood and the politics of the day, 'contributing to the production of cultural structures of feeling' (Richards 2023: 263).

In her show notes, Rykiel expressed her dresses' relationality with the external world:

La mode, la robe et le monde. En même temps que je fais la mode, j'invente ma vie qui est le corps de la robe avec mes passions, mes plaisirs, mes douleurs, mon regard politique, ma liberté, mes attentes. Je suis liée à l'instant parce que ma robe aujourd'hui témoigne. Elle est Europe Amérique Asie Juive Musulmane Catholique. [...] A l'affût de tout, bonheur, désespoir, art, sexe, ecologie, sociologie, elle avance.

(Rykiel 2005: n.pag.)²⁸



Figures 5a–c: Unknown, Sonia Rykiel, Marie-Claude Grumbach, Antoinette Fouque and Hélène Cixous at the demonstration in solidarity with ex-Yugoslavian women victims of war, 8 March 1993. © Éditions des femmes.

Rykiel spoke of a certain universality; her dress was related to the whole world, all cultures and religions, yet it was also the dress tied to her political views, her freedom and her expectations as a leading figure of the fashion industry as well as the sociocultural environment of the Left Bank.

This complex and contradictory relationality indicates how fashion design mediates between different affective dynamics.

Rykiel’s involvement with the MLF ranged from attending colloquia and protest marches, for example, about access to abortion and reproductive rights, against misogyny and feminicide or to support, amongst others, women victims of war (e.g. in Yugoslavia) and women activists in Francoist Spain, to signing petitions and featuring in the MLF/Psych et Po collective’s monthly journal *Femmes En Mouvement*, where she would talk about literature (by Hélène Cixous, Régine Deforges, Madeleine Chapsal, Marguerite Duras and Nathalie Sarraute) or her own work (Figure 5). With Deforges, she published a volume of intimate correspondence, *Casanova était une femme*, in 2006. Through her close friendship with Fouque, who was a former Ph.D. student of Roland Barthes and had entered into analysis with Jacques Lacan, she was exposed to circulating feminist psychoanalytic theory and contemporary women’s literature (related to Fouque’s publishing house Éditions des femmes). They often met to talk about ideas and the state of the world in the English pub in the middle of their two St Germain residences: ‘entre nous le Twickenham, pub de luxe, où l’on buvait du thé ou du whisky en refaisant le monde, cela dépendait de l’heure’ (Fouque 2008).²⁹ Fouque attended all of Rykiel’s fashion shows (as several other intellectual women did in the 1970s, including Régine Deforges, Marie-Claude Grumbach, Hélène Cixous and Marguerite Duras) and it is this social milieu of feminist thinkers that pervaded Rykiel’s creation, both in her fashion and in her writing, as in her memoir *Célébration 1968–1988*, published by Éditions des femmes. Through the collaborations, such as Rykiel’s illustrations for the ongoing *Encyclopedia of Women Creators* in 2013, published by Éditions des femmes, they participated in a practice of feminist world-making. Rykiel was also the subject of a documentary made by Fouque, *Sonia Rykiel: Rhapsody in Black* (2008), and her reading voice was recorded as part of the oral library of women’s voices in the MLF archives, La Bibliothèque des Voix.

As the above examples demonstrate, Rykiel and Fouque were both part of the intellectual French feminist environment and produced it. Cixous wrote of this continuity or blending between the self and the world, the I and the not-I, through the garment: ‘C’est une femme qui n’a pas d’angles. Une femme qui se coule dans le monde, une femme qui ne se coupe ni du monde ni d’elle-même’ (1985: 10).³⁰

Even though Rykiel was not a militant member of the MLF, she was part of the environment where it thrived: ‘J’ouvre le cortège des femmes remuantes’ (Rykiel 1979: 14).³¹ Her *démode* garments expressed in a material way the specific feminist mood of the day and place, tied to the ideas posited by, amongst others, Cixous and Fouque. Cixous stated that there was a pacifist attitude in the garments themselves:

La non-violence de ces vêtements [...] Le vêtement de Sonia c’est pour la paix. [...] Je suis mon amie et je suis l’amie du monde. [...] Un vêtement qui n’est pas une bruyante manifestation de rue, mais une fine manifestation du monde.

(Rykiel 1979: 38; Cixous 1985: 8–10)³²

life. It is dependent on the war, the strike, the massacres. It infiltrates me, it flows into my ideas. It explodes when I break out and calms down when I go to sleep.

28. Fashion, dress and the world. At the same time as I create fashion, I invent my life which is the body of the dress with my passions, my pleasures, my pains, my political outlook, my freedom, my expectations. I am linked to the moment because my dress today bears witness. She is Europe America Asia Jewish Muslim Catholic[...]. On the lookout for everything, happiness, despair, art, sex, ecology, sociology, she moves forward.

29. ‘Between us the Twickenham, a fancy pub, where we would drink tea or whisky whilst remaking the world, depending on the time of day’.

30. ‘It’s a woman without corners. A woman who flows into the world, a woman who does not cut herself off from the world nor from herself’.

31. ‘I open the parade of unruly women’.

32. The non-violence of these garments [...] Sonia’s garment is for peace [...]. I am my friend and I am friends with the world[...]. A garment that is not a noisy manifestation of the street, but a refined manifestation of the world.

Here, Cixous touches on the way the garments were part of the atmosphere or mood and how they manifested not the street but ‘the world’. They affiliated the designer, wearer, writer, family, the sociocultural environment and the world into a mood.

In conclusion, when looking at the evolution of Rykiel’s fashion creations, her emblematic designs evolved only ever so slightly throughout the decades, true to her own rules of the *démode*, which rejected trends and fads: ‘Evoluant mais ne révolutionnant pas ou peu’ (Rykiel 1979: 166). In this sense of continuity and repetition, she and her garment designs stopped being relational to the changing wider sociocultural moods and kept inhabiting the feminist moods of the early decades (1960s–70s), when she was a young woman who developed the *démode* philosophy. With Flatley, we can conclude that in fashion, too, we are often entangled in the mood-worlds that have been created or have been inhabited before.

By using concepts from mood theory, I have tried to disentangle and re-entwine the various relations and affiliations that are at play in the act of creating and wearing garments and fashion in the context of a certain sociocultural and feminist mood. Rykiel’s *démode* concept, both as a material as well as a discursive feminist practice, offers a well-posed use case that bridges the emotional, personal and social-political positions of feminism through material garments. I hope to have shown that the field of fashion studies can be enriched by relational perspectives, which allow us to analyse garments as objects that conjoin the wearer’s body, affect, ideas and personal mood with the wider social mood, where world-making happens.

ETHICAL STATEMENT

This article was researched and written to the standards of Intellect’s Ethical Guidelines: <https://www.intellectbooks.com/ethical-guidelines>. No approvals or subject consent were required.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The author has no conflicts of interest to declare.

FUNDING

The author received a grant from FWO Vlaanderen Senior Research Project Grant (G067824N) to aid in the research of this article.

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SUGGESTED CITATION

Van Godtsenhoven, Karen (2025), “‘Vivre l’époque’: A relational reading of mood, selfhood and feminist world-making in the work of Sonia Rykiel”, *International Journal of Fashion Studies*, Special Issue: ‘Affiliative Fashion, Relational Analysis and Power’, 12:2, pp. 197–215, https://doi.org/10.1386/infos_00137_1

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